

Session 10: Oaths and Vows

Key Takeaways

- Jesus doesn't quote a single command about vows and oaths. Instead, he summarizes and adapts various regulations from the Torah.
- The words translated as "oath" and "vow" have slightly different meanings, but together they encapsulate all the ways people try to add greater weight to a promise made to God or other humans.
- Jesus condemns the way people leverage religious language to manipulate others in order to get their way, calling on his followers to love and honor others through simple truthfulness.

Case Study 4: Oaths & Truthtelling

³³ Again, **you have heard that it was said** to the ancients,
"Do not break your oath,"
and "Repay to the Lord your vows."

³⁴ **And I tell you** ,
do not swear an oath at all:
not by the sky ,
because it is God's throne;
³⁵ **not by the land** ,
because it is the stool of his feet;
not by Jerusalem ,
because it is the city of the Great King.
³⁶ And **do not swear by your head** ,
for you cannot make even one hair white or black.

³⁷ But let your word be "Yes, yes" or "No, no";
anything beyond this comes from the evil one.

Matthew 5:33-37. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

Jesus doesn't quote from any one place in the Torah. Rather, his words are a paraphrase of multiple passages about oaths and vows.

Numbers 30:3 Instructor's Translation

If a man makes a vow (נדר / εὐξεται εὐχῆν) to the Lord, or takes an oath (שבועה / ὁμώσει ὄρκον) to bind himself with a binding obligation, he shall not violate his word; he shall do according to all that proceeds out of his mouth.

Leviticus 19:11–12 Instructor's Translation

Do not steal. Do not lie. Do not deceive one another.

Do not swear an oath falsely by my name and so profane the name of your God. I am Yahweh.

Deut 23:21-23 Instructor's Translation

When you make a vow (נדר / εὐξῆται εὐχῆν) to the Lord your God, you shall not delay to pay it, for it would be sin in you, and the Lord your God will surely require it of you. However, if you refrain from vowing, it would not be sin in you. You shall be careful to perform what goes out from your lips, just as you have voluntarily vowed to the Lord your God what you have promised.

Psalms 50:14 NASB

Offer to God a sacrifice of thanksgiving

and pay your vows (שלם נדריך / ἀπόδος...τὰς εὐχὰς σου) to the Most High;

Vows are promises made to God about sacrifices or offering that will be made if prayers are answered.

For example, in Genesis 28:20-22, Jacob makes a vow that if God is with him and keeps him safe, then upon returning to the land, Yahweh will become his god, he will make Bethel a place of worship to Yahweh, and he will give one-tenth of his wealth to Yahweh.

These are voluntary (Deut. 23:22), but once made, they are binding (Deut. 23:23).

Genesis 28:20–22 NASB

Then Jacob made a vow, saying,

“If God will be with me and will keep me on this journey that I take,

and will give me food to eat and garments to wear,

and I return to my father’s house in safety,

then the LORD will be my God.

This stone, which I have set up as a pillar, will be God’s house,

and of all that you give me I will surely give a tenth to you.”

Judges 11:30–31 NASB

Jephthah made a vow to the LORD and said,

“If you will indeed give the sons of Ammon into my hand,

then it shall be that whatever comes out of the doors of my house to meet me when I return in peace from the sons of Ammon, it shall be the LORD’s, and I will offer it up as a burnt offering.”

Oaths are promises made to other people, invoking God’s name as a guarantor of the trustworthiness of one’s promises or words. Invoking God to guarantee the truthfulness of one’s promise is what makes it so serious: to break that promise is a misuse of God’s name (Exod. 20:7), defiling it (Lev. 19:12).

Genesis 24:2-4 Instructor's Translation

Abraham said to his servant, the oldest of his household, who had charge of all that he owned, "Please place your hand under my thigh, and **I will make you swear and oath** (השבוע) **by Yahweh**, the God of heaven and the God of earth, that you shall not take a wife for my son from the daughters of the Canaanites, among whom I live, but you will go to my country and to my relatives, and take a wife for my son Isaac."

Exodus 22:10-11 Instructor's Translation

If a man gives his neighbor a donkey, an ox, a sheep, or any animal to keep for him, and it dies or is hurt or is driven away while no one is looking, **an oath** (שבועה) **before Yahweh** shall be made by the two of them that he has not laid hands on his neighbor's property; and its owner shall accept it, and he shall not make restitution.

In summary, oaths and vows were not necessary, nor are they ever commanded in the Old Testament. But the Old Testament laws recognize that people will make them, and they attempt to regulate the practice in order to prevent abuse.

Jesus gives four examples of oaths in [Matthew 5:34-36](#). In Jesus' day, there developed a practice of avoiding the use of the name of God or the word "God" (Elohim) in oaths and vows. Instead, other "valuable" substitutes were put in its place: the skies, the land, Jerusalem, your own head.

The practice Jesus alludes to is described in the Mishnah.

"Mishnah, Shavuot 4:13

A (1) "I impose an oath on you," (2) "I command you," (3) "I bind you,"—

look, these are liable.

B "By heaven and earth,"

look, these are exempt.

C (1) "By [the name of] Alef-dalet [Adonai]" or

(2) "Yud-he [Yahweh],"

(3) "By the Almighty,"

(4) "By Hosts,"

(5) "By him who is merciful and gracious,"

(6) "By him who is long-suffering and abundant in mercy," or by any other euphemism—

D look, these are liable."

Neusner, Jacob (1991). [The Mishnah: A New Translation](#). Yale University Press. 629.

Jesus refers to this practice later in Matthew.

Matthew 23:16-22 Instructor's Translation

¹⁶Woe to you, blind guides! You say,

"If anyone swears an oath by the **temple**, it means nothing;

but anyone who swears by **the gold of the temple** is bound by that oath.”

¹⁷You blind fools! Which is greater: **the gold, or the temple** that makes the gold sacred?

¹⁸You also say,

“If anyone swears by **the altar**, it means nothing;

but anyone who swears by **the gift on the altar** is bound by that oath.”

¹⁹You blind men! Which is greater: **the gift, or the altar** that makes the gift sacred?

²⁰Therefore, anyone who swears by **the altar** swears by it and by everything on it.

²¹And anyone who swears by **the temple** swears by it and by the one who dwells in it.

²²And anyone who swears by **the skies** swears by God’s throne and by the one who sits on it.

People had developed loopholes, based on the relative value of the object used in the oath. For example, “I swore by the temple that I would help you move your wagon today, but, gotcha, I didn’t swear by the gold of the temple! So, it wasn’t really a valid oath!”

The whole system just ticks Jesus off. He counters this practice by showing that all of these “lesser” substitutes for God are actually still invocations of God’s honor, after all.

The statement, “the skies are God’s throne and the earth is God’s footstool,” is derived from [Isaiah 66:1](#).

“Jerusalem is the city of the great king,” is from [Psalm 48:2](#). Finally, Jesus brings the examples close to home—the head you think is “yours.” In reality, you have no control over it (e.g., your hair color). Rather, your head is a gift from the creator, so you’re still using God in your vow.

Jesus also tells us that when we swear by our own head or life, we have not left God behind. For our physical life is not really our own; even the time for our hair to turn gray is in God’s hand. In other words, we are presumptuous to think we can enlist ourselves as warranty for our promises, as if we had final control over our lives. Even when we swear by ourselves, we are in fact invoking God, since it is God who will either keep us in the picture or take us out altogether (see Bruner).

The Heart of the Matter

“The essence of swearing oaths that Jesus targets here is about invoking something or someone else, especially God, to make your words seem more significant and weighty. The aim is to impress others with your seriousness or piety so that you get what you want. It’s a device of manipulation designed to override the judgment or input of others in order to possess them for our purposes. It’s manipulation, or, as we say in our culture, “spin.” Jesus says it’s evil: instead of loving and honoring others with truthfulness, the intent is to get one’s way by verbal manipulation of the thoughts and choices of others.”

Adapted from Willard, Dallas (1998). [The Divine Conspiracy](#). Harper.

Instead, Jesus advocates a simple truthfulness that doesn’t seek to manipulate others or siphon off of the integrity or honor of others. It is much easier to control people than to love them with transparency. It is much easier to manipulate other people’s perception of you than it is to be honest with others.

“God requires truthfulness. A simple Yes or No should be all that’s needed. As soon as it is necessary to bolster it with an oath in order to persuade others to believe what is said, the ideal of transparent truthfulness has been compromised.”

France, R. T. (2007). [*The Gospel of Matthew \(The New International Commentary on the New Testament\)*](#). Eerdmans. 216.

Matthew 5:37 “yes, yes and no no” (ἔστω δὲ ὁ λόγος ὑμῶν ναὶ ναί, οὐ οὐ)

- NIV: All you need to say is simply “Yes” or “No”
- ESV: Let what you say be simply “Yes” or “No”
- NASB: But let your statement be, “Yes, yes” or “No, no”
- Instructor's Translation: Let your word be “Yes, Yes” or “No, No”

James 5:12 is a summary of Jesus’ words here: Above all, my brothers and sisters, do not swear oaths—not by heaven or by earth or by anything else. All you need to say is a simple “Yes” or “No” (ἤτω δὲ ὑμῶν τὸ ναὶ ναὶ καὶ τὸ οὐ οὐ). Otherwise you will be condemned.

“Although one may well doubt whether Jesus intended his words about oaths to be an absolute rejection of all oaths instead of a polemic against ‘the evil habit of swearing incessantly and thoughtlessly about ordinary matters’ (Philo, Decal. 92) or a memorable way of requiring total honesty in every situation, it must be admitted that Matthew 5:33–37 has been taken from early times—and is still taken by some Quakers and many Anabaptists in our own day—as a blanket prohibition.”

Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2004). [*Matthew, vol. 1, \(International Critical Commentary\)*](#). T&T Clark International. 535.

Reflection Question

What is a reason people make oaths and vows that Jesus would reject?